Does unrest lead to armed conflict? Where we are DRAFT, 12 November 2026

The question. Protests and riots and armed conflict often happen in the same places. In Africa and the Middle East (2023–24), a cell-week with unrest has conflict 18% of the time, against 2% without. There are three possible reasons, and they matter differently for theory and policy:

1. **Escalation:** unrest leads to conflict, e.g. through repression or radicalisation.
2. **Shared places:** some places, such as capitals, contested towns and the administrative centres where ACLED places events of uncertain location, persistently record both, without one causing the other.
3. **Shared episodes:** a regional crisis (a coup, an election, a collapse of authority) raises both at the same time for months.

Simple correlations or forecasting models cannot tell these apart. Our model estimates all three at once.

What we do. The world is divided into cells of about 55 km, observed every week. For each cell-week we record whether any conflict event (battles, explosions/remote violence, violence against civilians) and any unrest event (protests, riots) occurred in ACLED. The model explains both together. It uses the cell's own recent history, climate, population, national conditions (GDP, democracy, food insecurity), country differences, persistent differences between places, and slowly moving regional "episodes". Escalation is measured as the extra risk of conflict in a cell after recent unrest *there*, once places and episodes are accounted for. The reverse direction, conflict leading to unrest, is measured too.

What we find so far (Africa and the Middle East, 2018–2024):

- **Escalation exists but is modest and local.** Recent unrest in a cell (previous four weeks) raises the odds of conflict there by roughly 4% after one event and 11% after five. A naive analysis that ignores shared places and episodes gives 10% and 29%.
- **Most of the co-occurrence is shared places and shared episodes**, not escalation. Accounting for persistent "hotspot" places alone cuts the apparent escalation effect by 40%.
- **No spillover to neighbouring cells** within a month, and no sign of unrest feeding conflict months later (preliminary).
- Knowing both outcomes does not forecast conflict better on average. It helps in some countries (Afghanistan) and hurts where the relation broke down (Yemen, Palestine, Sudan in 2023).

Caveat. ACLED records reported events, so every result mixes violence with reporting. Shared places partly capture where the media look.

Next. We now have all ACLED events from 1997 to 2025 and matching covariates worldwide. The next analysis asks *where* escalation is stronger or weaker: Africa (from 1997), the Middle East, South and Southeast Asia, and Latin America, with Europe as a contrast case (much unrest, almost no conflict). Checks on how much of each component the data really support are running now.

Where your input would help most:

1. Where would you *expect* escalation to be strongest? For example, autocracies against democracies, or particular regions or periods (Myanmar 2021, Sudan 2019–23, the Sahel). We would like to state expectations before we see the regional results.
2. Should "conflict" be split? State repression of protest (violence against civilians) and armed battles may escalate very differently.
3. Is four weeks a sensible window for escalation, or do the mechanisms you know act over months?
4. Which reporting biases in ACLED worry you most for this question?